SUNIL GAVASKAR'S RECORDS

THE LEGEND AND THE LEGACY

He was the one they wrote a calypso for. Like his spiritual son Sachin, he could rock too...if he wanted, very rarely. Mostly, he was classical. Sublime, perfect.

BY AMITABH SRIVASTAVA

Five five. Not a lot of inch tape above the mean sea level, but when you pack in unknowable tonnes of a substance called greatness, no scale suffices. How do you measure Sunil Gavaskar, the batsman? He left some vast amounts of tonnage out there for future statisticians to excavate and wonder at. One milestone came on a warm spring day in 1987 when, against Pakistan in Ahmedabad, he bent over low on the back foot to a nothing delivery from Ejaz Faqih for a late-cut past the wicketkeeper, and sprinted. That would become the first 10,000th Test run anyone with a willow had ever scored. The batsman's equivalent of the first Four-Minute Mile. Or Everest. We duly pick that here, to mark the onset of a phase where Indian batters bested the best. Including one who was like a bionic edition of Gavaskar. Also five foot five, also born in Bombay's Dadar, Sachin Tendulkar did indeed come like a second avatar, just more packed with TNT and hormones. The similarity didn't end with the phonetics of the name. The yen for scaling peaks was as unquenchable.

But there's no dearth of neutral peers who say Gavaskar was India's best, bar none. The man with a record 34 Test centuries was ironically out in his 90s in his very last inning, on a dustbowl

DID YOU KNOW?

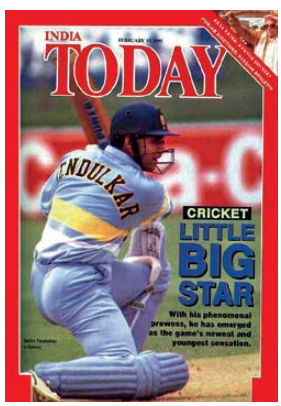
Gavaskar once joked that he'd personally strangle Sachin if he didn't reach at least 15,000 runs and 40 Test tons. Tendulkar got 15,921 and 51!

IT RAINED RUNS

- **Sunil Gavaskar, only 21 then, scores 774 runs at an average of 154.89 in his debut series, against the West Indies, in 1971**
- **It's the first benchmark of excellence for a country starved of sporting success**
- **With perfection writ all over his technique, and a Bradmanesque appetite, Sunny becomes an ideal**
- **As records tumble, his greatness spawns a whole new generation of heroes**
- **Sachin Tendulkar, Rahul Dravid get 10,000 in both Tests and ODIs. Virat Kohli is on the cusp of that double**

10,000
RUNS

Sunil Gavaskar became the first batsman in the history of Test cricket to reach that landmark on March 7, 1987



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